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Win UK kitchens where Check65 can't follow

A UK restaurant operations app: opening and closing checklists, food-safety due diligence (SFBB, temperatures, allergens), repairs and maintenance, and handbook/policies. Covers the UK competitors, operator pain points, regulation across the four nations, the market and go-to-market, and the recommended product plan.

> The UK opening is not another food-safety checklist app. **The self-serve price for digital SFBB and temperature logging has already fallen to about £19 per site per month on rolling terms** (Hubl, Lemon), with £4.99 diaries below that. The real opening is a single, fast, phone-first record of everything that decides an EHO's "confidence in management" score, an insurer's view of the premises, and an employment tribunal's view of the employer. That means food safety, opening and closing checks, repairs and maintenance tied to a statutory inspection calendar (gas, fire, TR19, EICR), and a handbook with employment records that keeps up with the Employment Rights Act 2025. Check65 is the field app of Food Alert's consultancy bundle. Food Alert is owned by Citation. The bundle is strong on regulatory content, advice lines and risk-assessment libraries. It is weak on price transparency, self-serve onboarding, and repairs and maintenance, and its public feature list shows no handbook. Trail, now owned by Access Group, is the visible mid-market incumbent at **£38–£82.50 per site per month on a 12-month minimum**. Hardware vendors such as Navitas lock buyers into 12–24 month contracts. The recommended beachhead is **independent and small-group (1–10 site) food-led pubs and restaurants in England and Wales**. Tenanted and leased pub estates (Star, Greene King, Admiral, Stonegate) and trade bodies (BII, UKHospitality) are the routes to scale, and the FSA's open FHRS data supports outbound targeting of 3- and 4-rated sites. Price should start at £19 to neutralise the anchor and earn its margin at about £39–£69 per site through the modules no £19 app has. Many statutory cadences and some legal thresholds below are flagged **[unverified]**. They must be checked against legislation.gov.uk, hse.gov.uk and FSA/FSS primary text before they become product rules or marketing claims.

A crowded £19 floor, a locked-in middle and a consultancy top

The UK market splits into four tiers, and each one leaves a different gap. At the bottom, cheap self-serve SFBB and temperature apps cost **£5–£32 per site per month**: SFBB+, SFBB Pro, Hubl, Lemon, food-safety.app and Leafe. Most of these are 2024–26 startups adding AI features. In the middle sit checklist and ops SaaS products at **£32–£83 per site per month, usually with 12-month minimums**: Trail, Paddl and FoodDocs. Then come hardware-plus-software sensor vendors on 12–24 month contracts, Navitas and Checkit. At the top are consultancy-bundled platforms sold on quote only: Food Alert's Alert65 and Check65, and probably Shield Safety and NSF (Hubl; Lemon; Trail pricing).

Check65 is the mobile front door to a Citation retainer

Food Alert presents Check65 as the "due diligence" app. It turns paper checklists into tasks with real-time status and mirrors an organisation's regions, sites, departments and users. It records deliveries, hot and cold food checks and visitor logs, logs corrective actions, supports international time zones, and feeds dashboards that work with BI tools. **Bluetooth temperature checking is sold as a separate offer**, and no price appears on the page (Food Alert). The App Store listing adds daily, weekly and monthly scheduled lists (opening and closing, cleaning, fire safety), ad-hoc lists such as visitor logs, hot checks (cooking, reheating, hot holding) and cold checks (cooling, ambient, fridge, freezer) (App Store). Behind it, Alert65 provides digital HACCP with **200+ templates**, **200+ consultant-written risk assessments** with version history, group policies that each site can customise, an allergen matrix and menu compliance, training tracking, certificate expiry reminders, RAG-scored accountability, complaints and incidents, and EHO visit preparation. It works offline and is ISO 27001 certified (Food Alert Alert65).

The commercial model matters more than the feature list. Alert65 is sold in Independent, Multisite and Enterprise packages alongside compliance membership, audits, consultancy, a **24/7 advice line**, HACCP development, training and allergen analysis. Food Alert claims **3,000+ businesses**, including Fuller's and Wasabi (Food Alert Alert65). The Citation Group bought Food Alert in 2019. Food Alert has since bought SureFoot, NT Assure, STS and Common Sense Compliance (Food Alert; Catering Today). Citation also sells HR, employment-law and health-and-safety retainers, so a combined "checklists + food safety + R&M + handbook" app competes with the whole Citation bundle, not just Check65. Food Alert runs PPC landing pages for the checklist app, which shows it wants standalone app buyers as well as consultancy clients (Food Alert PPC). One more detail shows how the market has tangled: **Trail sells a "Trail + Surefoot" bundle at £105 per site per month**, and Surefoot is a Food Alert/Citation company (Trail x Surefoot). The inference that Check65 usually reaches customers inside multi-year retainers rests on Citation's model rather than on a published contract term, so treat it as **[unverified]**.

Check65 feature by feature: match or beat

Check65 / Alert65 capability (per Food Alert)	Match or beat	How
Paper checklists turned into tasks with real-time status; scheduled daily, weekly and monthly lists (opening/closing, cleaning, fire safety) and ad-hoc lists	**Match, beat on setup**	Lists generated from an SFBB (England/Wales/NI) or CookSafe (Scotland) profile in under 15 minutes; shared-tablet PIN mode; auto-close at deadline
Hot checks (cook, reheat, hot hold), cold checks (cooling, ambient, fridge, freezer), delivery checks	**Match, beat on rules**	Nation-aware thresholds (8°C chill limit in E/W/NI, none in Scotland; 82°C reheat in Scotland **[unverified]**); guided cooling timer; flags for identical repeated readings
Corrective actions logged	**Beat**	A failed check opens a corrective action, then a work order on the specific asset, then a contractor visit with cost and certificate, all visible in the EHO pack
Visitor log	**Match**	Visitor and contractor sign-in linked to the job or statutory inspection the contractor is there for
Region → site → department → user hierarchy; role-based tasks	**Match, keep it light**	Built for 1–10 sites first, with estate and pubco views later
Dashboards, BI-compatible exports	**Match, beat on exceptions**	Exception-first manager feed (late, missed, failed, overdue certificates), weekly owner digest, one-tap EHO pack
Bluetooth temperature checking, sold separately	**Match later, don't require**	Software anti-falsification at launch; one vetted probe and partner sensors as optional add-ons
Digital HACCP, 200+ templates; 200+ risk assessments	**Partial match**	SFBB/CookSafe-native safe methods and a HACCP drafter (AI draft, human approval); partner with EHP consultants for risk-assessment libraries rather than writing 200 in-house
Allergen matrix and menu compliance	**Beat**	Recipe-level 14-allergen matrix with version history, written allergen sheet for front of house, PPDS (Natasha's Law) label fields, supplier spec change alerts
Training tracking, certificate expiry reminders	**Match**	Staff certificate vault plus statutory premises certificates (gas, EICR, TR19, fire) on one calendar
Group safety policies that sites can customise	**Beat**	Full employee handbook with e-signed acknowledgements, re-acknowledgement on change, and ERA 2025 evidence (harassment risk assessment, tipping policy consultation record)
Complaints and incidents; EHO visit preparation	**Match, beat on FHRS mapping**	Records grouped under the three FHRS elements so the operator sees "confidence in management" evidence before the visit
Offline; ISO 27001	**Match offline at launch; Cyber Essentials first, ISO 27001 by estate sales**	Offline-first capture with background sync
24/7 advice line, audits, consultancy	**Don't build; partner**	Referral marketplace of independent EHPs and trainers; Food Alert will always out-consult a software startup
Quote-only pricing in packages	**Beat**	Published GBP prices, rolling monthly terms, unlimited users, no setup fee

Check65 / Alert65 capability (per Food Alert)	Match or beat	How
Not on the public feature list: repairs and maintenance work orders, statutory inspection calendar, employee handbook, shift handover log, rota/EPOS-driven tasks	**The openings**	These form the paid tiers' core

UK competitor comparison in GBP

Prices are per site per month unless stated. "3P" means the figure comes from a competitor's blog, and "Agg" from an aggregator such as Capterra. Both are often stale or quote the wrong unit, so treat them as indicative.

Product (owner)	Price	Term	Food safety / checklists	R&M	Handbook / HR	Allergens	Main weakness vs the plan here	Source
Check65 / Alert65 (Food Alert → Citation)	Quote only	Not published	Strong, offline	Not in public list	Policies, risk assessments	Matrix	Opaque, consultancy-led	Food Alert
Trail Team / Standard / Evo (Access Group)	£38 / £75 / £82.50 (annual £32 / £65 / £71.50)	12-month minimum; 14-day trial	Yes; corrective actions from Standard	Via wider Access suite, not native	Evo: documents, policy management	Limited	Lock-in; Capterra UK reviewers cite a "clunky" mobile app and reports taking up to 30 minutes (Capterra)	Trail
Trail for BII members	3 months free, then £12	Cancel anytime	As above	—	—	—	Sets a partner floor	Trail BII
Trail + Surefoot	£105	n/k	Plus expert guidance	—	—	—	Premium bundle	Trail
Navitas	£129 Essential / £159 Pro (3P)	12 / 24 months (3P)	Probes, sensors, HACCP	No	Training	Labels	Hardware lock-in	Lemon
Checkit (historic)	£199 upfront + £19.99; Pro from £30 (Agg, about 2015)	Annual in advance	Sensors	No	No	—	Current price unpublished	ZoftwareHub
Hubl	£19; higher tiers from £32 (3P)	Rolling monthly	Yes, plus "Orbit" AI	No	No	Matrix	Food-safety only	Hubl
Lemon	£19	n/k; 14-day trial	Yes	No	Training included	Optional matrix	Food-safety only	Lemon
SFBB+	£4.99 (3P)	90-day trial	Digital SFBB diary	No	No	—	Single small sites only	Hubl
SFBB Pro (Guardstar)	£25.95 first site, £12.95 each extra; £99.95 printer (3P)	n/k	Yes, date labels	No	No	Yes	Narrow	Lemon
Paddl	£69 or £703.80/yr (3P)	Monthly or annual; card required	AI-drafted HACCP/SFBB	Equipment and licence tracking	No	—	Closest on equipment tracking, priced high	Paddl
Leafe	£28–£119 (3P)	n/k	Yes, plus inventory	No	No	—	FHRS-5 positioning but no R&M	Lemon
food-safety.app	£6.99 or £69.99/yr (3P)	n/k	Offline-first	No	No	—	Very basic	food-safety.app

Product (owner)	Price	Term	Food safety / checklists	R&M	Handbook / HR	Allergens	Main weakness vs the plan here	Source
Culinary Key	£40 (1–4 sites), £35 (5–9), £33 (10+) per vendor; Capterra says "from £40 per user"	Cancel anytime	Yes	No	No	—	Narrow scope	Culinary Key; Capterra
FoodDocs	£59–£73 (3P) or $99–$299 (sources conflict)	n/k	AI HACCP builder	No	No	—	Expensive for SMEs	Hubl
CompliChef	Not captured	n/k	Kitchen logs, EHO records	No	Staff HR, recruitment	PPDS labels	Nearest SME all-in-one; unknown traction	CompliChef
Nutritics Insight	£16 / £32 / £64 (Agg)	Billed annually	—	—	—	Recipe/allergen/nutrition depth	Point tool	Capterra
Kafoodle	From £20 (Agg)	n/k	—	—	—	Recipes, allergens	Point tool	Capterra
RotaCloud	£1/employee + £0.90 T&A + £0.40 SMS (Agg)	n/k	—	—	Rota	—	Integration partner	Capterra
BrightHR (Peninsula)	About £3–£17/employee (3P, low quality)	24–60 months (3P)	—	—	HR/handbook	—	HR lock-in, not ops	kaeltripton

Two conflicting Trail data points are **[unverified]**: a "from £11 per site" snippet and a "Trail Solo £14" plan, neither of which appears on the fetched pricing page. Navitas's £129/£159 comes only from a competitor's blog. The table makes the strategic point plain. **Repairs and maintenance is the least-served pillar among UK food-safety apps**. Paddl tracks equipment and licences, and the Access suite can bolt on property maintenance, but no SME product links a failed fridge check to a contractor job and a gas or TR19 certificate. Few players combine all four pillars. CompliChef is the nearest SME all-in-one, though its pricing and traction are unknown. At the enterprise end, the Citation bundle and Trail Evo inside the Access suite are the real competition (Access Group).

UK operators are short-staffed, cost-squeezed and exposed on allergens

The pressures that shape what UK operators will buy all point the same way: fewer staff, higher costs, and more liability on each record. **Hospitality has the highest staff turnover of any UK sector at 38.7%, and 47% in bars and clubs** (NatWest Mentor). Payrolled employees in accommodation and food services fell 4.1% to about 2.09 million in the year to August 2025 (RSM UK). Labour costs keep rising. The April 2025 employer NIC change pulled **774,000 hospitality workers into employer NICs, costing the sector about £1bn** (Caterer Licensee). The National Living Wage rose to **£12.71 from April 2026**, about £1.4bn of extra cost according to UKHospitality (Restaurant Online). Hospitality accounted for **53% of UK job losses** after the 2024 Budget (UKHospitality). The partial offset is the new permanently lower business-rates multiplier for retail, hospitality and leisure (RHL) premises in England from April 2026, which is 38.2p for rateable values under £51k (Morning Advertiser). It helps the small pubs and restaurants this plan targets most. Hotels face revaluation increases, which makes them a weaker first segment (UKHospitality). The product implication is

that the same checks get done by fewer, newer people. Onboarding, task guidance that needs no training, and records that build themselves matter more in the UK than in low-churn sectors. Software sold as "nice to have" will lose to software that saves manager hours or protects the rating.

Allergens are where the stakes are sharpest. Councils prosecuted three allergen cases in 2025:

- **Javitri in Uxbridge paid £43,816** after a customer was hospitalised. Officers found nuts stored incorrectly, incomplete menu descriptions and "uncertainty regarding recipes", even though staff had completed FSA allergen training that month (Hillingdon Council).
- **Pop-Inn Café in Southwark was fined £18,000** after the death of 12-year-old Mia-Shay St Hilaire (Southwark Council).
- **A Hartlepool takeaway was fined £10,000** after a test purchase found peanut protein (Hartlepool Council).

Javitri is the strongest product lesson in the research. Training alone fails without recipe-level allergen records tied to the live menu. The FSA's updated best-practice guidance for non-prepacked food in England, Wales and Northern Ireland now says written allergen information should always be available alongside a conversation with the customer. The law still permits verbal information (FSA; GOV.UK).

Complaints about the software itself carry over from the wider market. UK review data is thin: Trail has only seven Capterra UK reviews. They praise ease of use and support, and complain about a "little clunky" mobile app and reports that take up to 30 minutes (Capterra UK). Larger cross-market review sets show the same pattern the UK reviews hint at. Jolt users call the mobile app "slow and sometimes freezes up" and warn others about contract terms "locking you in" (Capterra; Software Advice). Crunchtime Ops reviewers cite slow image uploads, Bluetooth problems and "expensive hardware on top of monthly subscriptions" (G2). SafetyCulture's value depends on staff actually completing photos and notes (Capterra). Underneath all of it is **pencil-whipping**, meaning logs completed without the work being done. Staff do it because they are short of time, poorly trained, and believe nobody reads the logs (Crunchtime; Ladle). Hardware is the usual fix and also the top complaint, because Bluetooth and Wi-Fi struggle through stainless steel and insulated cold units (Refrigerated & Frozen Foods).

The research has three gaps. It did not retrieve UK operator forum voices from r/UKhospitality, r/chefit or The Caterer threads. It found no UK data on equipment breakdown frequency or contractor costs. It found no statistic on what share of operators still use paper SFBB diaries. The US analogue, a **median $22,500 a year on equipment repair and maintenance**, should not be quoted as a UK figure (Bar & Restaurant).

UK regulation rewards records, and the four nations differ in ways software must encode

FHRS turns record-keeping into a public score

The Food Hygiene Rating Scheme in England, Wales and Northern Ireland rates businesses 0–5 on three elements: hygienic food handling, physical condition, and **confidence in management**, which covers food safety management systems, training and procedures (GOV.UK/FSA). Hygiene and structure are each scored 0/5/10/15/20/25. Confidence in management is scored **0/5/10/20/30**, and the worst band means no evidence of documented food safety management. A total of 0–15 earns a 5, and above 50 earns a 0 (NCASS; Reigate & Banstead). An "additional scoring factor" lets a single bad element cap the overall rating (High Speed Training). The exact per-element caps are **[unverified]**: the FSA Brand Standard PDF returned a 404, and the figures in the notes come from memory. Display is a **legal requirement in Wales and Northern Ireland** and

voluntary in England (GOV.UK/FSA). Whether mandatory display has been legislated in England by October 2026 is **[unverified]**. A paid re-rating visit costs roughly **£175–£265**, depending on the council, and takes place within three months (Erewash; Gloucester). The 21-day appeal window and right-to-reply safeguards are **[unverified]**. Scotland uses a different scheme, FHIS, with Pass or Improvement Required, and its details were not fetched **[unverified]**.

This scoring structure is the product's sharpest ROI argument. Confidence in management is driven almost entirely by documentation, and one weak element can cap the rating. A digital diary that is complete, reviewed and recognisable as SFBB maps directly onto a scoring component.

SFBB explicitly accepts an electronic diary

The FSA's Safer Food Better Business packs come in versions for caterers, retailers, Indian cuisine, Chinese cuisine and childminders, plus a care-home supplement. Each covers cross-contamination, cleaning, chilling, cooking and management, with a diary for daily records and a **4-weekly review**. The FSA says the pack "must be completed for all your food operations" with daily records kept in the diary, and that businesses can keep an **electronic diary** (GOV.UK/FSA). The FSA has moved its business guidance from food.gov.uk to gov.uk, and old URLs now return 301 redirects, so any regulatory deep links in the app must point to gov.uk. The page-level content of each pack has not been checked: the opening and closing check lists, the safe-method names and the "prove it" checks. All of that, and CookSafe's contents for Scotland, is **[unverified]** and must be read from the PDFs before the templates are written.

Regulation-to-feature map by nation

Requirement	England	Wales	Scotland	NI	Feature	Status
HACCP-based FSMS, records proportionate to the business (retained Reg 852/2004 Art 5)	SFBB	SFBB	**CookSafe** (FSS)	SFBB variant	Nation profile generating safe methods, diary, 4-weekly review	SFBB e-diary sourced; legal basis and CookSafe contents **[unverified]**
Chill holding	≤8°C legal limit; 4-hour single excursion	Same	**No 8°C rule**; must be refrigerated or kept cool	Same as E/W	Threshold engine by nation; fridge target 5°C (SFBB guidance)	**[unverified]** against SI 2013/2996 Sch 4 and national equivalents
Hot holding	≥63°C; one 2-hour excursion	Same	Same principle	Same	Hot-hold timer	**[unverified]**
Cooking	Core 75°C instant or equivalent (70°C/2 min, 80°C/6 s) as SFBB guidance	Same	CookSafe guidance	Same	Probe check with time-temperature equivalents	Guidance, **[unverified]**
Reheating	75°C guidance	75°C guidance	**82°C legal requirement** unless it harms quality (corrects the earlier 75°C figure)	75°C guidance	Scotland-specific reheat rule	**[unverified]** against SSI 2006/3 Sch 4
Cooling	Within 90 minutes where possible (SFBB)	Same	CookSafe	Same	Guided cooling timer	Guidance, **[unverified]**
Rating scheme	FHRS, display voluntary	FHRS, **display mandatory**	**FHIS** Pass/Improvement Required	FHRS, **display mandatory**	EHO pack grouped by FHRS element; FHIS mode for Scotland; sticker reminder for W/NI	FHRS sourced; FHIS **[unverified]**

Requirement	England	Wales	Scotland	NI	Feature	Status
14 allergens; written info best practice for non-prepacked food	Yes	Yes	FSS guidance	Yes	Recipe-level matrix, written allergen sheet, change log	FSA guidance sourced; 14-allergen list **[unverified]**
Natasha's Law: PPDS labels with name and full ingredients, allergens emphasised (from 1 Oct 2021)	Yes	Parallel rules	Parallel rules	Parallel rules	PPDS label fields and printing	**[unverified]**
Fitness to work: exclude for 48 hours after diarrhoea or vomiting	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Illness and return-to-work log	**[unverified]**
Food handler training "commensurate with work activity"; Level 2 is expected, not statutory	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Certificate vault and training assignment	**[unverified]**
Fire safety law	RRO 2005	RRO 2005	Fire (Scotland) Act 2005	Fire Safety Regs (NI) 2010	Fire risk assessment record, test logs	**[unverified]**
Recorded fire risk assessment for all responsible persons, including assessor identity (Building Safety Act 2022 s156, from 1 Oct 2023)	Yes	Yes	n/a	n/a	FRA upload with assessor and review date	**[unverified]**
Alcohol licensing: DPS, age-verification policy; Challenge 25 mandatory in Scotland	Licensing Act 2003	Same	Licensing (Scotland) Act 2005	Licensing (NI) Order 1996	Refusals log, DPS record, licence conditions checklist	**[unverified]**
Employment Rights Act 2025	Yes	Yes	Yes	**Largely does not extend**	HR records module	Dates sourced (law firms); NI extent **[unverified]**
Tips allocation (Employment (Allocation of Tips) Act 2023), fully in force 1 Oct 2024	Yes	Yes	Yes	Not confirmed	Written tipping policy, allocation records	In force sourced (legislation.gov.uk); 3-year record duty **[unverified]**
Martyn's Law (200+ capacity)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Capacity field; SIA notification and procedures workflow	Act sourced; UK-wide extent **[unverified]**

EHO inspection frequency adds a further moving part. Hygiene risk categories run A–E. The traditional minimum intervals are 6 months for A, 12 months for B, 18 for C, 24 for D, and an alternative strategy for E. Those intervals are **[unverified]** and will change under the FSA's hygiene delivery-model reform. The Food Standards Delivery Model has been statutory for English councils since 1 April 2025 (FSA). Enforcement is intensifying. In 2025/26, formal enforcement actions reached their highest yearly volume in more than ten years, complaints exceeded 64,000, and councils achieved 98.2% of due interventions for A- and B-rated premises (FSA September 2026 Board).

Martyn's Law matters to large venues and to estates

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025 with an implementation period of at least 24 months, and the SIA is the regulator. Guidance published in 2026 covers statutory guidance, notification and "principal use" (GOV.UK). The **Standard tier (200–799 people, staff included)** requires public protection procedures for evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication, plus notification to the SIA. The **Enhanced tier (800+)** adds security measures, a documented plan and a designated senior individual (Foot Anstey). Standard-tier penalties reach £10,000 plus £500 a day (Keoghs).

Enforcement is expected from spring 2027, but the exact commencement date is **[unverified]**. The sources also disagree on when the final statutory guidance was published: 15 April 2026 or 25 August 2026. Most restaurants hold fewer than 200 people. Large pubs, venues with function rooms and food halls do cross the threshold, which makes this a modest but real feature for pub estates. Store a capacity figure per site. At 200 or more, generate the notification task, the procedures template, staff briefing records and a review cycle.

Employment Rights Act 2025: a timeline the handbook must track

Date	Change	Feature
In force since 1 Oct 2024	Tips must go to workers in full; written tipping policy (legislation.gov.uk). The 3-year record duty and the worker's right to request records are **[unverified]**	Tipping policy, allocation ledger, record requests
Since 26 Oct 2024	Duty to take reasonable steps to prevent sexual harassment **[unverified]**	Policy, risk assessment, training record
April 2026	SSP from day one, lower earnings limit removed; day-one paternity and parental leave; **6-year holiday pay record duty**; Fair Work Agency from 7 April (Lewis Silkin)	Sickness log feeding SSP; holiday ledger with 6-year retention
1 Oct 2026	Tribunal claim limit rises from 3 to 6 months (Blake Morgan)	Longer evidence retention for disciplinaries and grievances
30 Oct 2026	Duty to take "**all** reasonable steps" against sexual harassment; liability for harassment by third parties such as customers (Blake Morgan)	Customer-harassment incident log, updated policy with re-acknowledgement, training assignment
Oct 2026 or end 2026 (**sources conflict**)	Duty to consult workers on the tipping policy and review it every 3 years. Some sources say October 2026 (Moore Kingston Smith); Lewis Silkin reports a delay to the end of 2026 while the Code is reviewed	Consultation workflow with a timestamped record and a 3-year review reminder
Oct 2026 or Jan 2027 (**sources conflict**)	Written statement of the right to join a union	Template statement in onboarding
Jan 2027	Unfair-dismissal qualifying period falls to 6 months; compensation cap removed; fire-and-rehire restrictions (Lewis Silkin)	Probation reviews, documented performance process
2027	Guaranteed hours for zero-hours workers; reasonable shift notice and pay for short-notice cancellation; bereavement leave (April 2027)	Rota integration timestamps on when shifts were offered, changed and cancelled

The gov.uk ERA roadmap page returned a 404, so these dates rest on law-firm summaries that agree on the main points. Long-standing retention periods should also become automated timers once verified: national minimum wage records 6 years, Working Time records 2 years, right-to-work copies for the employment plus 2 years, pension records 6 years, and right-to-work civil penalties of up to £45,000 for a first breach and £60,000 for a repeat. All of these are **[unverified]**. The research does not support turning the app into payroll or a full HR system against BrightHR or Citation. The right scope is evidence: policies, acknowledgements, logs and timestamps that an employer can produce at a tribunal.

The statutory maintenance-compliance calendar

This calendar is the most under-served opportunity in the UK research. Every interval below is **[unverified]**: none was re-fetched from hse.gov.uk, legislation.gov.uk, BESA or the British Standards this session. The product should ship these as editable defaults that a professional has reviewed, never as hard-coded law.

Item	Typical cadence	Basis	Evidence the app stores
Gas appliances	Annual inspection by a Gas Safe engineer; commercial catering certificate (often called CP42); ventilation interlock per BS 6173	Gas Safety (Installation and Use) Regs 1998 reg 35	Certificate, engineer Gas Safe number, remedials
Kitchen extract ductwork	TR19 Grease: about quarterly for heavy use (12–16 h/day), 6-monthly for moderate, annual for light; insurers often require a certificate	BESA TR19	Before and after photos, certificate, next due date set by usage
Fire alarm	Weekly test of a different call point	BS 5839-1	Weekly log entry

Item	Typical cadence	Basis	Evidence the app stores
Emergency lighting	Monthly functional test; annual full-duration test	BS 5266-1	Log entries, contractor certificate
Fire risk assessment	Recorded, reviewed periodically	RRO 2005 / BSA 2022 s156 (E&W); separate Scottish and NI law	FRA document, assessor identity, actions tracker
Fixed electrical installation	EICR about every 5 years for commercial premises (guidance; statutory only for private rented housing in England)	EAW Regs 1989, BS 7671/IET	EICR, C1/C2 remedials as work orders
Portable appliances	Risk-based, not annual by law	IET Code of Practice	Asset register, test dates
Lifting equipment	Thorough examination every 12 months for goods-only dumbwaiters; 6 months if people ride (corrects "6-monthly dumbwaiters")	LOLER 1998	Examination report
Pressure systems	Written scheme of examination where in scope (e.g. espresso boilers above 250 bar·litres)	PSSR 2000	Written scheme, inspection reports
Legionella	Risk assessment; monthly sentinel tap temperatures; keep records 5 years	HSE ACOP L8 / HSG274	Temperature log, assessment
COSHH	Assessments and safety data sheets	COSHH 2002	SDS library
Accidents	Accident book; RIDDOR records kept 3 years; over-7-day injuries reported within 15 days	RIDDOR 2013	Incident log with RIDDOR prompt
Pest control	Contract and visit reports	Food hygiene / FHRS physical condition	Visit reports, sightings log linked to work orders
Waste	Waste transfer notes kept 2 years; hazardous consignment notes 3 years	EPA 1990 s34	Note uploads with retention timers
First aid	Needs assessment	First-Aid Regs 1981	Assessment, first-aider certificates

The calendar is what turns "repairs and maintenance" from a ticket log into a compliance asset. A failed EICR C2 item, an overdue TR19 clean or a missing gas certificate all show up beside the fridge that ran warm. Each one becomes a work order to a contractor, and each closes with an uploaded certificate. Insurers, landlords and pubcos care about exactly this evidence.

The opportunity: 98,600 licensed sites, 104,000 new food businesses a year, and an FHRS map to all of them

The widest universe is the **590,000 UK food establishments** the FSA regulates. Of those, **36,000 are unrated**, and **about 104,000 new food businesses registered in 2025/26, up 8.7%** (FSA September 2026 Board). That universe includes care homes, schools and retailers. The licensed on-trade core is far smaller: **98,564 GB licensed premises at the end of June 2026**, flat on the quarter. That figure hides heavy churn, with **1,839 closures and 1,794 openings in Q2 2026** alone, about 20 a day each way (NIQ/CGA). Independents lost nearly a fifth of their sites in five years, but they grew 0.9% in Q3 2025 (CGA). Bar numbers grew 1.4% year on year, and city centres outperformed the wider market (NIQ).

A rough bottom-up estimate, which is an inference rather than a sourced figure, puts the addressable UK market at **about £34–£135M a year**. It takes roughly 150,000–250,000 food-service sites (licensed venues plus cafés, takeaways and contract catering) at £19–£45 per site per month. The site count is **[unverified]** because ONS SIC 56 local-unit counts were not extracted. That is a niche, not a venture-scale market on its own. It argues for capital efficiency and for the higher-value modules rather than pure food-safety logging.

FHRS data reshapes the sales pitch. **78% of UK businesses are rated 5 and 97% are rated 3 or above** (FSA). "Avoid a zero" therefore speaks to only about 3% of the market. High Speed Training's analysis of the FHRS API reaches a different picture. For England, Wales and NI combined it puts 72.33% at 5 and **11.69% at**

3 or below. It finds **19.5% of takeaways at 3 or below**, puts London **10th of 11 regions** with an average of 4.39, and counts 501 premises rated 0 (High Speed Training). The two sources measure different populations, so their figures differ. The commercial message that follows is "**get to 5, stay at 5, and prove it at the next visit**". It is aimed at the 3s and 4s, recently re-rated sites, new registrations and unrated businesses. Each rating is public and timestamped through the FSA's open API, so targeting is unusually precise (FSA FHRS). Displayed stickers make the reputational stake visible. Only **5% of 0–2 rated English businesses display their sticker, against 81% of 5-rated ones** (FSA Audit of Display 2025).

Recommended UK beachhead: food-led independents and small groups in England and Wales

The beachhead is **independent and small-group (1–10 site) food-led pubs and restaurants in England and Wales**. Takeaways come in as a self-serve secondary segment, and Scotland and NI follow once their rules packs are built. Five reasons support this choice. First, England and Wales share SFBB, the 8°C/63°C regime and FHRS, so one rules pack covers most of the market, while Scotland's CookSafe, 82°C reheat and FHIS need a separate pack. Second, food-led pubs and restaurants feel all four pillars at once: food safety, a building full of gas, extraction and electrics, staff turnover, and tipping. That is where a combined product justifies more than £19. Third, tenanted and leased pubs can be reached in bulk through pubcos, which have regulatory and brand reasons to monitor tenant compliance. Star Pubs & Bars already deployed Shield Safety's software with a traffic-light remote view (Shield Safety). Greene King Pub Partners spent **£200k on a licensee app** (Caterer Licensee). Fourth, multi-site owners with 2–10 sites feel the "I can't be everywhere" pain and pay per site. Fifth, the Wales rule that ratings must be displayed sharpens the stakes there.

The main argument against this beachhead deserves weight. Takeaways have the worst ratings, and new registrations are the largest inflow, so a pure FHRS-improvement product might grow faster there. These segments, however, are exactly where £4.99–£19 apps already compete, and they have the lowest willingness to pay for maintenance or HR features. Serve them with an entry tier and outbound FHRS campaigns, but do not design the product around them. Hotels are deprioritised because of revaluation-driven cost spikes, and contract catering because it is dominated by enterprise buyers.

The product: compliance as the wedge, the building as the moat

Module plan: MVP versus later phases

Module	MVP (months 0–6)	Phase 2 (6–12)	Phase 3 (12–24)
1. Daily ops and checklists	Opening, closing and cleaning lists generated from the nation profile; scheduled and ad-hoc lists; photo, number, yes/no and signature fields; shared-tablet PIN mode; auto-close and late flags; offline-first sync	Shift handover log (incidents, 86'd items, maintenance notes carried to the next manager); scored manager walk-rounds	Brand-standard audits for estates and franchises; cross-site benchmarking
2. SFBB / CookSafe food safety	SFBB-native diary with daily sign-off and **4-weekly review**; fridge, freezer, delivery, cook, reheat, hot-hold and cooling checks with nation-aware thresholds; mandatory corrective action on failure; fitness-to-work and return-to-work log	CookSafe pack for Scotland; FHIS mode; AI-drafted safe methods and HACCP with human approval; one vetted Bluetooth probe	Partner wireless sensors (resold, not built); supplier approval and traceability
3. Allergens	14-allergen matrix per dish, recipe-level ingredients, version history, printable written allergen sheet for front of house	PPDS (Natasha's Law) label fields and printing; supplier spec-change alerts; menu sync from EPOS	Nutritics or Kafoodle integration for groups with recipe systems

Module	MVP (months 0–6)	Phase 2 (6–12)	Phase 3 (12–24)
4. Repairs and maintenance	Asset register with a QR sticker per unit; one-tap fault report with photo; fault becomes a work order with status, contractor and cost; failed temperature check creates a work order automatically	**Statutory compliance calendar** (gas, TR19, fire alarm, emergency lighting, EICR, LOLER, PSSR, legionella, pest, waste notes) with certificate upload and reminders; contractor dispatch by SMS or email link with no contractor login; visitor sign-in tied to jobs	Warranty and spend by asset; repair-versus-replace insight; landlord and pubco shared view of building compliance
5. Handbook and people records	Handbook builder from UK templates; e-signed acknowledgements with re-acknowledgement on change; staff certificate vault (Level 2/3 food hygiene, personal licence, first aid) with expiry alerts	ERA 2025 evidence pack: harassment risk assessment and third-party harassment log, tipping policy with consultation record and allocation ledger, holiday ledger with 6-year retention, SSP sickness log; onboarding checklist (right to work, written statement)	2027 shift-notice and cancellation records via rota integration; microlearning; multilingual content
6. EHO pack and records	Immutable audit trail with server timestamps; one-tap "EHO pack" PDF and read-only view grouped by FHRS element (handling, structure, confidence in management)	FHRS status tracker pulled from the FSA API, with re-visit request guidance and a rating-history chart	Insurer and pubco evidence exports (opt-in)
7. Manager feed and alerts	Exception-first feed (late, missed, failed, overdue certificate); escalation only when not done; weekly owner email	Multi-site league table; anomaly flags (identical repeated readings, lists completed in seconds)	AI weekly summary across food safety, maintenance and people
8. Platform	Three surfaces from day one: **tablet kiosk app** (iPad and Android tablets), **phone app** (iOS and Android) and **desktop web console**, built on one shared codebase (e.g. React Native + web) and one sync engine; UK English; GBP billing; CSV export; Cyber Essentials	Epos Now, Square and Lightspeed integrations; Deputy and RotaCloud staff sync; Martyn's Law capacity workflow for 200+ sites; webhooks and API	ISO 27001; SSO; estate admin for pubcos; Scotland and NI full rules packs

Founding team notes, mapped into the plan

The founding team's working notes set out the initial scope: food safety first, on **tablet and desktop** (now extended to **tablet, phone and desktop**), with a management console inspired by Check65. The notes list opening and closing checklists, a repairs and maintenance log, a handbook and policy area with **customisable checkpoints carrying the operator's own images, videos and descriptions**, a **spreadsheet summary and end-of-day report** for managers, and four user types: Manager, Staff, Admin and Accounting/Finance. That scope fits the research well. Here is how each idea slots in, and where the research suggests extending it.

Team note	Where it sits in the plan	Recommended expansion
Food safety first	Modules 1–3 and 6 are the MVP	Right call. Food safety is the reason to buy and the FHRS score is the hook. Ship repairs and the handbook as the reasons to stay.
Tablet + phone + desktop (decided)	Module 8 (Platform)	All three ship in the MVP, each with a clear job (see the device table below). One codebase and one offline sync engine keep the cost of three surfaces manageable.
Management console (Check65-style)	Modules 6–7	Lead with **exceptions, not a wall of green**: what was missed, late or failed, and which certificates are overdue. Then drill down by site, then by checklist, then by individual check. Check65 already offers a "smart dashboard"; the exception feed and auto-escalation are where to beat it.
Opening and closing checklists	Module 1	Generate the checklists from the site's nation (England, Wales, Scotland, NI) and venue type, so setup takes minutes. Add auto-close at the deadline, late flags and a shift handover note.
Repairs and maintenance log	Module 4	Extend the log into the **closed loop**: a QR sticker on each asset, a fault photo that becomes a work order, an SMS link to the contractor, cost logged against the asset, and the **statutory calendar** (gas, TR19, fire, EICR). This is the clearest gap versus Check65.
Handbook / policy with customisable checkpoints, images, videos and descriptions	Modules 1 and 5	Make it one **"checkpoint" builder** used everywhere. Every question can carry a "how to do it right" image, video or description, so a checklist doubles as **on-the-job training**. That matters with 38–47% annual staff turnover. Policies get e-signed acknowledgements and re-sign automatically when a policy changes. Ship with UK template packs (SFBB, allergens, ERA 2025 policies) so operators edit rather than start from blank.
Spreadsheet summary of all checkpoints for managers	Module 6–7	A **grid view** with sites or days as rows, checkpoints as columns and colour-coded cells, plus one-click **Excel/CSV export**. Keep the read-only EHO pack PDF separate.

Team note	Where it sits in the plan	Recommended expansion
End-of-day report	Module 7	Send it automatically at closing time by email and in-app. It covers completion %, failures and the corrective actions taken, temperature exceptions, faults opened or closed, and anything carried over to tomorrow. Add a weekly owner digest and the **SFBB 4-weekly review** prompt.
Users: Manager, Staff, Admin, Accounting/Finance	Module 8 permissions	See the role matrix below. Accounting/Finance is a strong, rarely served role: repair spend, contractor invoices and cost per asset. A later export to **Xero, QuickBooks or Sage**, common UK small-business accounts packages, is a natural phase-2 integration. Consider an **Owner / Area Manager** role for multi-site groups, and a **read-only Inspector/EHO link**.

Device strategy (decided: tablet, phone and desktop from MVP):

Surface	Primary users	Main jobs	Design rules
Tablet (kitchen/bar kiosk)	Staff, shift managers	Opening/closing and cleaning checklists, temperature checks, delivery checks, fault reports with photo, handbook sign-off, viewing checkpoint how-to images and videos	Shared device, 4-digit PIN per person with auto-lock; large tap targets for wet or gloved hands; works fully offline; wall-mount or stand; Bluetooth probe pairing in phase 2
Phone	Managers, owners/area managers; staff optionally	Alerts for missed, late or failed checks; sign-off of corrective actions; close-the-day; end-of-day report; raise and approve work orders; snap a fault photo anywhere on site; QR scan of an asset; receive policy updates	Personal login with biometric unlock; push notifications only for exceptions; the same checklists available as on the tablet so a manager can cover if the tablet is down
Desktop (web console)	Admin, managers, Accounting/Finance, owners	Checklist and checkpoint builder (with image/video upload), handbook and policy editor, spreadsheet summary grid, Excel/CSV export, EHO pack, maintenance calendar and contractor records, spend by asset, users/sites/roles and billing	Browser-based, no install; multi-site views; bulk editing; read-only inspector link

Phone apps must work for staff in phase 1 too, so very small sites (cafés, takeaways) can run without buying a tablet. That keeps the free and £19 tiers viable.

Suggested role and permission matrix (to validate with operators):

Capability	Staff	Manager	Admin	Accounting/Finance	Owner/Area Mgr (suggested)
Complete checklists, temperature checks and fault reports (tablet PIN or phone)	✓	✓	✓	–	✓
Read and sign handbook and policies	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sign off corrective actions, close the day, run the 4-weekly review	–	✓	✓	–	✓
Spreadsheet summary and end-of-day report	Own tasks only	Own site(s)	All sites	Cost views only	All sites
Raise and assign work orders, dispatch contractors	Report only	✓	✓	–	✓
Repair costs, invoices, spend by asset, accounting export	–	View	✓	✓	✓
Build checklists, checkpoints, policies and media	–	Site-level edits	✓	–	✓
Manage users, sites, roles and billing	–	–	✓	Billing only	✓
Generate the EHO pack or share a read-only inspector link	–	✓	✓	–	✓

Seven differentiators that beat Check65, Trail and the £19 apps

The **first differentiator is the closed loop from check to certificate**. A fridge reads 9°C at opening. In England that is above the 8°C legal limit **[unverified threshold]**. The app demands a corrective action, re-checks the unit in 30 minutes, and opens a work order on that specific fridge from its QR record. It texts the

refrigeration contractor a link and logs the visit, cost and invoice against the asset. The whole chain then appears in the EHO pack under confidence in management. Check65 records corrective actions, Trail paywalls them at its £75 Standard tier (Trail), and none of the £19 apps reaches a contractor.

The **second is the statutory calendar for the building**. No food-safety app in the UK research presents gas, TR19, EICR, fire and legionella obligations as one calendar with certificates and work orders. For a pub tenant, that is the difference between a food-safety app and the tool that runs compliance for the premises.

The **third is SFBB and CookSafe fidelity**. The diary, the 4-weekly review and the safe-method structure mirror the FSA pack, so an EHO recognises the system on sight. A Scotland profile encodes CookSafe, FHIS and the 82°C reheat rule **[unverified]**. Generic checklist tools and US entrants do not do this.

The **fourth is resistance to pencil-whipping without mandatory hardware**. The app accepts only live-capture photos, records server timestamps, flags identical repeated readings and implausibly fast completion, auto-closes lists at deadline, and prompts random spot checks. Probes and sensors become an upsell, not a 12–24 month hardware contract.

The **fifth is employment evidence for 2026–27**. Harassment prevention, third-party harassment, tipping consultation, holiday records and soon shift-notice records arrive on a fixed timeline. A handbook that updates, re-collects signatures and logs the evidence is a concrete reason to pay above £19. It also directly contests the part of the Citation bundle that Food Alert's app does not cover.

The **sixth is speed and fit for a real kitchen**. Targets are under 2 seconds to open a list, under 1 second per tap, full offline capture and background photo upload. A shared tablet with a 4-digit PIN per staff member suits a team that turns over 38–47% a year better than individual logins do.

The **seventh is commercial terms**. Prices are published in GBP, terms are rolling monthly, users are unlimited, there is no setup fee, and support runs in-app with a published response time. This answers the most emotional complaints in cross-market reviews, about lock-in and unresponsive support. It also contrasts directly with Trail's 12-month minimum and Navitas's 12–24 month terms.

AI belongs only where it is grounded and reviewable. That means drafting safe methods, HACCP and handbook sections from templates; answering staff questions from the operator's own approved documents; checking photo evidence; and summarising the week. Hubl's "Orbit" and Paddl's AI-drafted HACCP already make AI table stakes at the low end (Hubl; Paddl), so AI is not a differentiator on its own.

AI features: where it earns its place

AI is already table stakes at the low end of the UK market. Hubl has an "Orbit" assistant, Paddl and FoodDocs draft HACCP plans with AI, and Toast IQ answers operational questions inside the POS. So "has AI" is not a differentiator on its own. The edge comes from applying AI to **data only this app holds**: the closed loop of checks, faults, assets, contractors and policies. Three rules apply throughout. **AI never sets a legal threshold or signs anything off**; a named human approves. **Answers cite the operator's own approved documents**, or the app says it doesn't know. **Core logging never depends on AI**, so the tablet keeps working offline.

AI feature	What it does	Who it helps	Device	Phase
Ask your logs (search and analysis)	Managers type or say a question in plain English and get the answer, a table or chart, and links to the exact records behind it. See the examples below	Manager, Owner, Finance, Admin	All (best on desktop and phone)	**MVP. This is the headline AI feature**
Snap-to-setup	Photograph or upload the paper SFBB diary, existing checklists, cleaning rota or Word handbook, and AI turns them into editable digital checklists, checkpoints and policies	Owner, Admin	Desktop, phone	**MVP**. This attacks the "setup is overwhelming" complaint directly

AI feature	What it does	Who it helps	Device	Phase
Ask the handbook	Staff ask in plain language, e.g. "what temp should the walk-in be?" or "what do I do if a customer says they're allergic to sesame?". The answer comes only from the site's approved handbook, SFBB safe methods and allergen matrix, with a link to the source	Staff, new starters	Tablet, phone	**MVP**
Read the thermometer	The camera reads the probe or fridge display and fills in the temperature, and checks that the photo matches the number entered	Staff, Manager	Tablet, phone	**MVP**. This makes pencil-whipping harder without extra hardware
Photo-and-voice fault reports	Snap the broken fryer and say what's wrong. AI identifies the asset (or reads its QR code), writes the work order, suggests urgency and drafts the message to the contractor	Staff, Manager	Phone, tablet	**MVP**
AI end-of-day and weekly summary	Turns the day's checks, failures, corrective actions and faults into a short plain-English report, and drafts the SFBB 4-weekly review for the manager to edit and sign	Manager, Owner	Phone, desktop	**MVP**
Translate everything	Checkpoints, how-to descriptions, policies and video subtitles appear in each staff member's language, while the signed English master stays the legal version	Staff	All	Phase 2
Allergen assistant	Reads supplier spec sheets and ingredient-label photos, proposes the 14-allergen matrix per dish, and flags when a supplier changes a recipe. A manager must approve every change	Manager, Chef	Desktop, phone	Phase 2. High liability, so it stays human-approved and versioned
Early warnings on equipment	Spots a fridge creeping warmer over days, or a unit that keeps failing checks, and raises a "service it before it fails" work order. One walk-in freezer failure cost £23.8k in the research	Manager, Owner	Phone	Phase 2
Pencil-whip detection	Flags identical readings day after day, lists completed in seconds, and photos reused or taken off-site	Manager, Owner	Desktop, phone	Phase 2
Mock EHO inspection	Reviews the last 4–12 weeks of records against the three FHRS elements, highlights gaps that would weaken "confidence in management", and builds a fix-it list	Owner, Manager	Desktop	Phase 2
Policy and HACCP drafting	Drafts safe methods, HACCP and ERA 2025 policies (tipping, harassment risk assessment) from vetted UK templates and the site's own setup. Each draft goes to a human, and ideally to a partner consultant or lawyer, before publishing	Admin, Owner	Desktop	Phase 2
Invoice reading for Finance	Reads contractor invoices (photo or email), matches each one to its work order and asset, and builds cost per asset and repair-versus-replace advice; exports to Xero, QuickBooks or Sage	Accounting/Finance	Desktop	Phase 3

Ask your logs: the headline AI feature

Every check, temperature, corrective action, fault, work order, invoice, policy sign-off and certificate the app stores becomes **searchable and analysable in plain English**. Competitors give dashboards and exports. This gives every manager an analyst. It is also the AI feature that improves as the closed loop gathers data, so it is hard for a £19 checklist app to copy.

Type	Example questions	What comes back
Search	"Show every time the walk-in was above 8°C in September." · "Who signed off the cooling log on 12 August?" · "Find the photo of the fryer fault last month." · "Any notes mentioning mice or droppings this year?"	The matching records with time, person, photo and corrective action, each linking to the original entry
Analysis	"Which site misses closing checks most, and on which days?" · "Is fridge 2 getting warmer week on week?" · "Which checklists are completed suspiciously fast?" · "How many corrective actions were still open at close this month?"	A short written answer plus a chart or table, with an "add to dashboard" option
Money (Finance role)	"How much have we spent on refrigeration repairs this year, by site?" · "Which contractor has the slowest response time?" · "Is it cheaper to replace the ice machine than keep repairing it?"	Cost totals, trends and cost per asset; exportable to Excel, Xero, QuickBooks or Sage
Compliance	"Are we ready for an EHO visit?" · "Which staff haven't signed the new harassment policy?" · "Which certificates expire in the next 60 days?" · "Build me the EHO pack for the last 3 months."	A gap list ranked by FHRS element; one-tap pack or reminder sends

Type	Example questions	What comes back
Explain	"Why did yesterday's end-of-day report show 3 failures?" · "What changed at the Brixton site since its rating dropped?"	A plain-English explanation that cites the records it used

How it works, and how it stays safe:

- **The AI calls the app's own query tools** (filter by site, date, check type, asset, person; aggregate; chart) rather than writing free-form database queries. Answers then always match the real data and respect what each role may see. Staff see only their own tasks; Finance sees costs but not, for example, staff health records.
- **Every answer cites its records.** If the data does not answer the question, it says so rather than guessing.
- **Free-text notes, photos and voice notes are indexed for meaning** (semantic search), so "mice" also finds "droppings behind the dry store".
- **Saved questions become scheduled reports.** For example, "every Monday, email me last week's temperature failures by site". This replaces most hand-built reports, and feeds the end-of-day report and the spreadsheet summary from the founding team's notes.
- **Answers can be exported or pinned.** Any answer can go to Excel/CSV, into the EHO pack, or onto the dashboard.

How to build it. Use a hosted LLM API with vision, such as Anthropic's Claude: a larger model for document and photo understanding and drafting, and a small fast model for classification and translation. Keep retrieval scoped to each operator's own documents. Store prompts, sources and outputs alongside the audit trail, so every AI suggestion can be traced. Process data under UK GDPR with a data processing agreement and no training on customer data. Cap AI usage per plan so the £19 tier stays profitable. A sensible split is snap-to-setup and ask-the-handbook in every tier, with the mock inspection, early warnings and allergen assistant in the £39+ tiers.

Price at the £19 anchor, earn margin on the building and the people

Clear published prices make the UK pricing landscape easy to read. The **self-serve food-safety anchor is about £19 per site per month on rolling terms** (Hubl, Lemon). Trail's entry is £38 (£32 billed annually) with a 12-month minimum, and the BII member rate is £12 after three free months (Trail BII). Navitas reportedly charges £129–£159 on 12–24 month contracts (3P). Rota tools charge about £1 per employee per month (Capterra). A combined app replacing two or three tools can plausibly charge £35–£60, but buyers will compare it line by line with £19 food-safety apps. The tiers below are recommendations to test, not sourced price points.

Plan	Price (per site/month, ex VAT)	Includes
Diary (free, 1 site)	£0	SFBB diary, temperature checks, 4-weekly review, EHO pack PDF, 90-day history. Acquisition for new registrations and takeaways; competes with £4.99 SFBB+
Essentials	**£19** rolling (about £16 annual)	Unlimited history and users, all food-safety checks with corrective actions, allergen matrix, opening and closing lists, basic fault log
Operator	**£39** rolling (about £33 annual)	Everything above plus full repairs and maintenance with work orders and contractor dispatch, statutory compliance calendar, handbook with e-acknowledgements, ERA 2025 evidence pack, multi-site feed. Priced against Trail Team (£38 on a 12-month minimum) with far more scope and no lock-in
Group	**£59–£69** rolling	EPOS and rota integrations, AI drafting, PPDS labels, probe and sensor support, league tables, API
Estate / pubco	£10–£15 per tenant site, paid or co-funded by the pubco	Estate dashboard with a traffic-light view of tenant compliance, central policy distribution. Matches the BII £12 and Star–Shield precedents

Plan	Price (per site/month, ex VAT)	Includes
Hardware	Near cost, optional	One vetted Bluetooth probe; sensors through a partner

Two levers make the maths easier. An insurer discount like the earlier **Towergate–Checkit deal of £60–£100 per site per year** offsets £5–£8 a month, which is a third to almost half of Essentials. That deal is historic, from about the late 2010s, and its current status is unknown (The Caterer). A **£175–£265 FHRS re-visit fee** avoided, or a single allergen prosecution like Javitri's £43,816, dwarfs a year of subscription. The churn data also argues for rolling terms. About 1 in 14 licensed sites closes each year, so lock-in contracts mostly create bad debt and resentment, not retention.

UK go-to-market: five channels in priority order

Pub company estate deals give the most leverage, because one contract brings many sites and the pubco has a reason to pay. Shield Safety's Star Pubs deal gives licensees audits, an EHO helpline and mobile software, and lets Star monitor compliance remotely. Shield says checks take 30–60 seconds (Shield Safety). Greene King's £200k licensee app shows pubcos will fund tenant-facing tools (Caterer Licensee). The pitch to a pubco is building compliance across the estate (gas, TR19, fire, EICR) plus FHRS protection, and that pitch is stronger than food safety alone. No evidence was found that Admiral or Stonegate currently mandate an app, so that is open ground **[unverified]**.

Trade-body member pricing comes second: the BII, UKHospitality and NCASS for street food. Trail's BII offer shows the format (3 months free, then a discounted rate) (Trail BII). **EPOS and rota marketplaces** come third. Trail integrates with Epos Now and Deputy, Epos Now reportedly lists 150+ apps **[unverified]**, and Access claims "1,500+ apps" across its suite (Trail BII; Access Group). Marketplace terms for Lightspeed, Square UK, Zonal and SumUp were not researched. **Insurers** come fourth: a premium discount for documented compliance, with TR19 and gas certificates as the evidence insurers already ask for. Only the historic Towergate–Checkit deal is evidenced. Hiscox, Simply Business, Markel and NFU Mutual were not checked. **FHRS open-data outbound** comes fifth and runs continuously. Pull 3- and 4-rated sites, newly rated sites and unrated new registrations from the FSA API, then send "get to 5 and prove it" campaigns by postcode, with London and takeaways as high-yield pockets (High Speed Training). Food hygiene trainers such as High Speed Training, and independent EHP consultants, double as content partners and as the advice layer this plan deliberately does not build.

Phased roadmap

Phase	Timing	Goal	Exit criteria
0. Validate	Weeks 0–8	25–30 interviews with 1–10 site pub and restaurant operators in England and Wales; 3–5 EHO conversations; 2–3 pubco BDM conversations; clickable prototype; read the SFBB Caterers and CookSafe PDFs; have an EHP and an employment lawyer verify every **[unverified]** rule	10 design partners; ranked buying triggers; verified rules pack v1 for England and Wales
1. MVP	Months 2–6	Checklists, SFBB diary and checks, allergen matrix, fault-to-work-order loop, handbook acknowledgements, EHO pack, offline mobile	Design partners use it at least 5 days a week for 8 weeks; at least one real EHO visit uses the EHO pack; a zero-paper site
2. Paid launch	Months 6–12	Self-serve GBP billing; statutory calendar; ERA 2025 evidence pack (harassment from 30 Oct 2026, tipping consultation); FHRS tracker; Epos Now and Deputy integrations; first probe	200–400 paying sites; monthly logo churn under 3% excluding closures; one trade-body deal
3. Estates and nations	Months 12–24	Pubco estate dashboard; CookSafe/FHIS Scotland pack; NI pack; Martyn's Law workflow before spring 2027 enforcement **[unverified date]**; 2027 shift-notice records; insurer pilot; ISO 27001	One pubco estate of 100+ tenant sites; 1,500+ paying sites
4. Platform	24+ months	Contractor network and marketplace, estate benchmarking, insurer data products	Positioned for strategic partnership or acquisition

Risks and the questions operators must answer

The biggest risk is **bundle competition from above**. Citation can sell food safety, HR, employment-law advice and H&S as one retainer. Access can bundle Trail with EPOS, rota and property maintenance. Either could add a work-order module. The mitigation is to win on what bundles do badly: speed, self-serve onboarding, rolling terms and a single building-and-people record that a small operator can set up in 15 minutes. The second risk is **price compression from below**. £19 AI-equipped startups appear every year, so Essentials must stay competitive and the margin must come from the R&M, calendar and handbook tiers. If operators will not pay £39 for that bundle, the thesis fails, and this is the first thing to test. The third is **customer fragility**. About 1,800 licensed sites close every quarter, and independents remain the most volatile segment. Pubco estate contracts and multi-site groups dampen this. The fourth is **regulatory liability**. A wrong threshold or cadence could mislead an operator, and many of the rules here are **[unverified]**. The mitigation is versioned rules packs signed off by an EHP, visible sources inside the app, editable defaults, and terms that keep the operator responsible. The fifth is **scope creep into HR**. Payroll, rota and full HR belong to RotaCloud, Deputy, BrightHR and Citation. Integrate with them rather than rebuilding them. Further risks follow. Category exits have priced at mid-single-digit ARR multiples: Digi bought Jolt for about $145.5M on more than $20M ARR (Business Wire). With a UK market of perhaps £34–£135M a year, that argues for capital-efficient growth.

Open question to validate	Why it matters	How to test
Will 1–10 site pub and restaurant operators pay about £39 for food safety plus R&M plus handbook, or only £19 for food safety?	Core pricing thesis	Fake-door pricing page; Van Westendorp survey in interviews
What triggers the purchase: an EHO visit or rating, an insurer or landlord demand, a staff or tribunal issue, or an equipment failure?	MVP emphasis and messaging	Interview ranking exercise; landing-page A/B
Do EHOs actually review digital SFBB diaries, and what convinces them under confidence in management?	Value of the EHO pack	3–5 EHO and EHP conversations
Will pubcos (Admiral, Stonegate, Star, Greene King) fund or mandate a tenant compliance app, and which records do they want to see?	Estate channel economics	BDM conversations; one pilot
What share of UK operators still use paper SFBB, and which app do switchers leave?	Sizing and positioning	Survey via BII or NCASS; FHRS outbound response rates
Which statutory certificates do insurers ask for at renewal, and will any discount premiums for them?	Insurer channel	Outreach to Towergate, Hiscox, Simply Business, NFU Mutual
Is software-only anti-falsification enough, or do operators and estates insist on probes and sensors?	Hardware strategy	Pilots with and without probes
Are the **[unverified]** thresholds and cadences correct for each nation (Scottish 82°C reheat, 8°C rule, FHRS caps, TR19 bands, LOLER, EICR, Martyn's Law commencement, ERA dates in NI)?	Rules-pack correctness and liability	EHP plus employment-lawyer review against legislation.gov.uk, hse.gov.uk, FSA/FSS and SIA
When does the tipping consultation duty actually commence: October 2026 or end of 2026?	Feature timing	Monitor DBT/Acas Code publication
What do UK operators say unprompted on r/UKhospitality, r/chefit and The Caterer forums?	No UK forum voice in the research	Manual review before Phase 0 ends
What are UK equipment-repair costs and frequencies?	ROI story for R&M (only US data exists)	Design-partner invoice audits; contractor interviews

Conclusion

The UK research changes the plan in one important way. The £19 rolling-term apps have commoditised food-safety logging, so a UK entrant that leads with "digital SFBB" is entering a price war it cannot win. The defensible product treats the FHRS confidence-in-management score as the hook, then becomes the compliance record for the whole premises and workforce: the gas certificate, the TR19 clean, the fridge that failed and who fixed it, the harassment policy every new starter signed, and the tipping consultation. Those

are the records no £19 app holds. Check65 holds them only inside a consultancy retainer. Trail holds them only inside a 12-month contract and the Access suite.

The second insight concerns channels. In the UK the buyer and the payer are often different organisations. A pubco, an insurer or a landlord has more reason to pay for building-level compliance evidence than a tenant does to pay for temperature logs. Pricing that starts at the market's £19 anchor, combined with estate and insurer deals that move the cost off the operator, is the most credible route past both Citation's bundle and the low-cost crowd. That route depends on getting the four nations' rules right, which is why verifying the **[unverified]** items is the first engineering task, not the last.